



The Booking Call

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 8 of 18 · Getting the Load · about a 13-minute read

You've done everything right. You found the perfect load — doable, a broker who checks out, a fair rate on the board. You pick up the phone to book it... and you freeze. You don't know what to say first. You don't have the load's numbers in front of you. The broker asks a simple question and you fumble it, and thirty seconds in, you sound like someone who's never done this. Now that broker is quietly wondering whether your truck is even real.

Meanwhile, another dispatcher called on that same load right after you. She was ready — knew her numbers, ran a tight, calm three-minute call, confirmed the details, locked the rate. She got the load. You didn't.

The load board finds the load, but the call is what gets it. And a good booking call isn't charm or luck — it's a structure, the same handful of steps every time, that you can run in your sleep.

WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Run a booking call from "hello" to "it's booked" — walking in prepared, moving through the call in a clear order, confirming every detail that matters, and hanging up with the load locked and the broker thinking, "that person knows what they're doing." You'll have a structure you can reuse on every call you ever make.

1 What It Is, and Why It's Make-or-Break

The booking call is the phone call where you and the broker agree to put your truck on their load. It's usually short — a few minutes — but it does a lot of heavy lifting: it confirms the load is still open and real, it settles the rate, it nails down the logistics, and it kicks off the paperwork.

Two things ride on every one of these calls. The obvious one is the load itself — getting it, at a fair rate. The one new dispatchers miss is the *impression*: the broker is deciding, in those few minutes, whether you're a pro worth calling again or a headache to avoid. Brokers have loads to move every single day, and they hand the easy, repeat business to carriers who make their lives simple. So a clean booking call isn't just today's load — it's the next fifty. And the dispatchers who win these calls aren't the smoothest talkers. They're the most *prepared* and the most *structured*. Let's build both.

2 Before You Dial: Prepare

The single biggest difference between a green call and a pro call happens *before* you pick up the phone. Never dial a broker cold and unprepared. Have these four things in front of you:

Your prep sheet · two minutes to pull together

1

The load details. The lane, the equipment, the weight and commodity, the pickup and delivery dates, and the posted rate — pulled off the posting so you're not guessing.

2

Your numbers. What this load costs you to run (your cost-per-mile), your **target rate**, and your **floor** — the lowest you'll accept. Know them before the broker says a word about rate, so you're never doing math under pressure.

3

Your truck and driver. Where your driver is, what equipment he has, and when he's available — because the broker's first question is almost always "what do you have, and where is it?"

4

Anything still open from vetting that you want to confirm.

With that in front of you, there is no question a broker can ask that catches you flat-footed — and that calm readiness is exactly what makes you sound like a pro. This is also where those call-note habits from the phone lesson earn their keep: notes ready before you dial, pen moving during the call.

3 The Structure of the Call

Here's the skeleton, and you run it in this order every time. Six steps.

1

Open. Identify yourself and your company, and name the load. *"Hi, this is [your name] with Summit Carriers — I'm calling on your load from Atlanta to Dallas, picking up Tuesday."* Clear, confident, specific.

2

Confirm it's still available. Before anything else: is the load still open? Loads get covered fast, and there's no point negotiating something that's already gone. Ask early.

3

Confirm the details. Verify the facts before you commit: pickup and delivery locations and dates, equipment, weight, commodity, and any special requirements. Postings can be stale or vague — make sure the load is actually what it said.

4

Talk rate. Where you and the broker agree on the number, working from the target and floor you walked in with. Agreeing on that number *well* is a skill all its own — a whole lesson — but for the booking call itself it's simpler: **know your number going in, and don't agree to anything below your floor.**

5

Confirm logistics and expectations. Pickup and delivery appointment times or windows (or agree that you'll set them), plus anything the load requires. Get clear on the timeline you just committed your driver to.

6

Lock it and set next steps. Agree to book it, and confirm what happens now: the broker sends a **rate confirmation** — the written document that makes the deal official — and you send your carrier packet if they need it. Before you hang up, both of you know exactly who does what next.

Open, confirm it's there, confirm the details, rate, logistics, lock. That's the call.

4 Sounding Like a Pro While You Do It

You already learned *how* to carry yourself on the phone in an earlier lesson — this is just that, aimed at the booking call:

What loses the load	What books it
Dials cold, fumbling for numbers mid-call	Be ready and calm — prep does this for you
Assumes the details, gets surprised later	Listen, then confirm back — repeat the facts, get a yes
Trusts it all to memory	Write it down as you go — rate, dates, names, requirements
Drama, slow callbacks, hard to reach	Be easy to deal with — that's what gets you re-booked

That confirm-back is the habit that does the most work: "*So that's picking up Tuesday at 8 a.m. in Atlanta, delivering Thursday in Dallas, dry van, about thirty-eight thousand pounds — correct?*" It catches mistakes before they become problems and signals that you're sharp.

5 After You Hang Up: Lock It Down Before It Goes Cold

The call isn't quite the finish line. The moment you hang up:

- 1 Write down everything agreed** — while it's fresh. Rate, pickup and delivery, appointment times, any requirements, and the broker's contact info.
- 2 Watch for the rate confirmation.** That written document is the real record of the deal (its own lesson covers it in full). Until you have the deal *in writing*, treat the load as promised, not finished.
- 3 Tell your driver.** He needs to know what he just got committed to — where, when, and what.

THE PRINCIPLE TO BURN IN

A verbal "yes" *starts* the load; the paperwork *makes it real*. A booking call that ends with a confident verbal agreement and a rate confirmation on the way is a booking call done right.

Walkthrough — A Booking Call, Start to Finish

Summit booking the anchor load with Smith Logistics. Read it as the script for your own first calls.

YOU

"Hi, this is [your name] with Summit Carriers — I'm calling on your Atlanta-to-Dallas load picking up Tuesday. Is that still available?"

BROKER "It is. What do you have?"

YOU

"I've got a dry van in the Atlanta area, empty and ready for Tuesday. Before we talk numbers — let me confirm: picking up Tuesday in Atlanta, delivering Thursday in Dallas, dry van, about 38,000 pounds of furniture. That all correct?"

BROKER "That's right."

YOU

"Great. It's posted at two thousand — can you do any better?"

→ **The rate step.** How you push here — anchor, counter, hold, walk — is the **negotiation lesson**, coming up next. For the booking call, you simply know your target and your floor, and you don't go below the floor.

BROKER "Two thousand's the number on this one."

YOU

"Okay — two thousand works. So to recap: Summit Carriers, dry van, pickup Tuesday in Atlanta, deliver Thursday in Dallas, two thousand all-in. What are the pickup and delivery appointment times, and where should I send my carrier packet?"

BROKER *[gives appointment windows + email]*

YOU

"Perfect. Send the rate confirmation over and I'll get it signed and have my driver headed that way."

Common mistake to avoid: jumping straight to "what's it pay?" before confirming the load is even still available and the details match. Run the structure — availability and details first — so you never negotiate a load that's gone or commit to one that isn't what you thought.

Notice what that call did: opened clean, confirmed the load was still there, confirmed the details with a confirm-back, handled the rate lightly (the *skill* of pushing on it is its own lesson), recapped everything, pinned the logistics, and set the next steps — rate con and packet. Three minutes, fully in control, and the broker's first impression of Summit is "easy, professional, knows the job." That's the whole game.

Module 8 Glossary — your quick reference

The booking call mostly applies words you already know. One new term, plus the three it points ahead to.

New here

Book a load / booking To agree with a broker to put your truck on their load — the verbal commitment the booking call produces, made official by the rate confirmation.

Named here, taught in their own lessons

Rate confirmation	The written document that makes a booked load official — covered in full in its own lesson.
Target rate & floor	The number you aim for and the lowest you'll accept — worked out in the money and load-board lessons; you walk into the call knowing both.
Rate negotiation	The craft of agreeing on the number well — anchoring, countering, when to walk — its own lesson, coming up next.

Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below.

- 1. What's the single most important thing you do before a booking call, and name two things you should have in front of you?**
- 2. List the main steps of a booking call in order.**
- 3. A broker answers and immediately says "it pays two grand." What should you do before agreeing?**
- 4. When is a load truly "booked"?**
- 5. How do you make sure you and the broker actually agree on the details?**

ANSWERS

- 1.** Prepare. Have the load details (lane, equipment, weight, dates, posted rate), your numbers (cost, target rate, floor), and your truck/driver info — any two.
- 2.** Open / identify → confirm it's still available → confirm the details → talk rate → confirm logistics → lock it + next steps.
- 3.** Don't skip the structure — confirm the load is still available and the details match what you expected, then handle rate against your known target and floor. (Agreeing to the number well is the negotiation skill, its own lesson.)
- 4.** Not on the verbal yes alone — when it's confirmed in writing (the rate confirmation). Verbal starts it; the paperwork makes it real.
- 5.** Confirm-back — repeat the key facts (pickup/delivery, dates, equipment, weight, rate) and get a yes — and write everything down as you go.

WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 9: NEGOTIATING THE RATE

Now you can run a clean booking call from start to finish. But you probably noticed we walked right up to one step and then stepped around it — the rate. Agreeing on that number is the part where real money is won and lost, and it's a craft all its own: knowing what to ask for, how to answer when the broker pushes back, and when to walk away from a bad number. That's exactly where we're headed next — negotiating the rate.

YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson teaches the booking call as a generic structure. Your own operation adds its specifics — its booking-call script and the exact prep sheet a dispatcher fills before dialing; its rate targets and floors by lane and equipment; the non-negotiable details it requires confirmed on every call; how a booked load gets logged in its system and handed off to dispatch; and its expectations for broker relationships. *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*